

the door for further decentralization and the use of public blockchains.

The potential applications of private blockchains extend far beyond the financial services industry. Banks and other monetary intermediaries have most quickly moved to adopt the technology because the use cases are most obvious for a system that specializes in securing transactions. Beyond the financial services industry, others that are exploring the applications of blockchain technology include the music industry, real estate, insurance, healthcare, networking, polling, supply chains, charities, gun tracking, law enforcement, governments, and more.⁶

Throughout this book, we will focus on public blockchains and their native assets, or what we will define as *cryptoassets*, because we believe this is where the greatest opportunity awaits the innovative investor. Sometimes, cryptoassets have the exact same name as their parent blockchain but with different capitalization. Other times there's a slightly different name for the asset. For example, the native asset of Bitcoin's blockchain is bitcoin, the native asset of Ethereum's blockchain is ether, the native asset of Litecoin's blockchain is litecoin, etc.

Many public blockchains are markedly different from one another. Some members of the early Bitcoin community feel the definition of what makes something a blockchain should be very specific, in particular, that any blockchain must use proof-of-work as the means of consensus. We disagree with that exclusive worldview, as there are many other interesting